the furtherance of the Buddhist religion.'[56] Sahni also believed that originally Ashokan pillars had been erected here. This was what the hundred-odd polished Chunar stone pieces and several thousand small fragments that he found there seemed to suggest. The pieces included a fragment from the base and one broken from the shaft summit which preserved part of the well-cut tapering hole into which a metallic bolt slid to support the abacus of the capital that crowned the pillar. Obviously, the pillars were battered into tiny bits at some later point in time.



Fig.10.12: Chunar monolithic railing at Sarnath

Fortunately, the monoliths with a specific message for the Buddhist community have survived better. The most famous one is the pillar at Sarnath with its superbly carved quadruple lion capital, the national symbol of India since Independence. Sarnath, some 5 km north of Banaras, is where Buddha preached his first sermon to his first disciples. The symbol of that first sermon, a wheel flanked by two deer, would later become the accepted